

Word family: **ever**

Base word: ever

Part of speech: mainly **adverb**

Related forms / useful extensions:

Ever does not have a large productive word family in the ordinary sense. It is best learned through its many high-frequency constructions and fixed expressions.

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **have ever done**

* **the best / worst / biggest ever**

* **ever since**

* **ever before**

* **ever after**

* **hardly ever**

* **rarely ever**

* **if ever**

* **ever so**

* **ever more**

* **ever increasing**

* **ever present / ever-present**

* **for ever / forever**

* **ever again**

* **than ever**

* **more than ever**

* **as ever**

* **ever such**

* **ever the optimist**

* **ever closer / ever larger / ever greater**

Meaning in this passage

> ...I still think it was one of the best presents I have **ever** given.

Here, **ever** means:

at any time in my life up to now — 曾經；任何時候

The speaker is comparing this gift with **all the presents he has given at any point in his life up to the present**.

中文翻譯：

直到今天，我仍然覺得那是我**曾經送過的**最好禮物之一。

So here:

have ever given = 到目前為止曾經送過

1. **ever (任何時候；曾經) — 曾經；有沒有**

This is the core use, especially in questions and perfect tenses.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> It was one of the best presents I have **ever** given.

那是我**曾經送過的**最好禮物之一。

Practice 2

> Have you **ever** been to Japan?

你**曾經**去過日本嗎？

Practice 3

> That's the funniest thing I've **ever** heard.

那是我**有生以來聽過最搞笑的事情**。

MCQ-ready definition:

ever = at any time, especially when talking about life experience up to now

中文：

在任何時候；尤其用來表示到目前為止曾否有過某種經歷

2. **Have you ever...? — 你曾經.....嗎？**

A major present-perfect pattern.

Practice 1

> Have you **ever tried** making a photo album by hand?

你**曾經試過**親手做相簿嗎？

Practice 2

> Have you **ever met** someone famous?

你**曾經見過**名人嗎？

MCQ-ready definition:

Have you ever + past participle...? = 問某人在到目前為止的人生中是否曾有過某種經歷

3. **the best / worst / most X ever** — 有史以來 / 我曾經.....過最.....的

Practice 1

> This is the best gift I've **ever received**.

這是我**曾經收過最好的禮物**。

Practice 2

> That was the hardest exam I've **ever taken**.

那是我**曾經考過最難的考試**。

MCQ-ready definition:

superlative + ever = 在所有過去至今的經歷中最.....

4. **the best ever** — 歷來最好；有史以來最佳

Practice 1

> Some fans think this is their **best album ever**.

有些粉絲認為這是他們**歷來最好的一張專輯**。

Practice 2

> It was the team's **best performance ever**.

那是球隊**有史以來最佳的表現**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****best/worst/etc. ever = 比以前任何時候或例子都更極端的****

5. ****ever before — 以前任何時候；從前曾經****

Practice 1

> The city is busier than ****ever before****.

這個城市比****以前任何時候****都更繁忙。

Practice 2

> She felt more confident than ****ever before****.

她比****以往任何時候****都更有信心。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****ever before = at any earlier time****

中文：

****以前任何時候；從前****

6. ****than ever — 比以往任何時候更……****

Practice 1

> She is busier ****than ever****.

她比****以往任何時候都更忙****。

Practice 2

> Family memories matter more to me ****than ever****.

家庭回憶現在對我來說比****以往任何時候都更重要****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****than ever = more than at any previous time****

7. **more than ever — 比以往任何時候更加.....**

Practice 1

> We need patience **more than ever**.

我們現在比**以往任何時候都更需要耐性**。

Practice 2

> She values family time **more than ever**.

她現在比**以往任何時候都更珍惜家庭時間**。

MCQ-ready definition:

more than ever = to a greater degree than at any previous time

8. **ever since — 自從.....以來一直**

A major distinct construction.

Practice 1

> I've loved photography **ever since** I was a child.

我**自小以來一直**喜歡攝影。

Practice 2

> She has kept the album **ever since** I gave it to her.

自從我把相簿送給她後，她**一直保存到現在**。

MCQ-ready definition:

ever since = continuously from a particular past time until now

中文：

自從某個過去時間開始，一直持續到現在

9. **ever since + clause — 自從.....之後一直**

Practice 1

> He's been happier **ever since he changed jobs**.

他**自從轉工後一直**比較開心。

Practice 2

> I've remembered that moment **ever since it happened**.

那件事發生後，我**一直記得那一刻**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****ever since + past clause = 從某件過去事情發生後一直到現在****

10. **ever after — 從此以後；此後一直**

Often literary or story-like.

Practice 1

> They lived happily **ever after**.

他們從此**幸福地生活下去**。

Practice 2

> The event changed his life **ever after**.

那件事令他**此後的人生一直受到影響**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****ever after = from that time onward, especially in stories****

中文：

****從那時起一直到後來；常帶故事語氣****

11. **hardly ever — 幾乎從不**

Very common.

Practice 1

> She **hardly ever** buys things for herself.

她**幾乎從不**為自己買東西。

Practice 2

> I **hardly ever** watch television now.

我現在**幾乎不看電視**。

MCQ-ready definition:

hardly ever = almost never

中文：

幾乎從不；極少

12. **rarely ever** — 幾乎很少；極少

Practice 1

> He **rarely ever** complains.

他**幾乎很少**投訴。

Practice 2

> We **rarely ever** eat out during the week.

我們平日**極少**外出吃飯。

MCQ-ready definition:

rarely ever = very seldom

Usage note: Often simply **rarely** is enough; **rarely ever** adds emphasis.

13. **if ever** — 如果真的有的話；即使有，也很少

A useful advanced construction.

Practice 1

> He rarely, **if ever**, talks about his childhood.

他很少談自己的童年，**即使有也幾乎沒有**。

Practice 2

> Such opportunities are difficult, **if ever**, to find.

這類機會非常難找，**甚至可能根本找不到**。

MCQ-ready definition:

if ever = used to emphasize that something happens very rarely or perhaps never

14. **ever again** — 再一次；以後再也

Practice 1

> I don't want to make that mistake **ever again**.

我以後**再也不想**犯那個錯。

Practice 2

> Will we **ever see each other again**?

我們**還會不會再見面**？

MCQ-ready definition:

ever again = at any future time after now

中文：

從現在以後的任何時候再一次

15. **never ever** — 絕對不；永遠不

Strong emphasis.

Practice 1

> I will **never ever** forget that day.

我**永遠都不會**忘記那一天。

Practice 2

> Don't **ever** do that again.

以後**絕對不要**再那樣做。

MCQ-ready definition:

never ever = emphatic form of never

中文：

強烈表示絕對不會 / 永遠不會

16. **ever + comparative — 愈來愈.....；不斷更加.....**

A useful formal/literary pattern.

Practice 1

> The problem became **ever more complicated**.

問題變得**愈來愈複雜**。

Practice 2

> Demand grew **ever greater**.

需求變得**愈來愈大**。

MCQ-ready definition:

ever + comparative = increasingly; continuously becoming more

中文：

愈來愈.....；持續變得更加.....

17. **ever increasing / ever-growing** — 不斷增加的

Practice 1

> We face an **ever-increasing demand** for housing.

我們面對**不斷增加的**住屋需求。

Practice 2

> The city has an **ever-growing population**.

這個城市有**持續增長的人口**。

MCQ-ready definition:

ever-increasing/growing = continuing to increase over time

18. **ever-present** — 無時無刻存在的；一直存在的

Practice 1

> Stress was an **ever-present problem**.

壓力是一個**一直存在的問題**。

Practice 2

> The mountains were an **ever-present feature** of the landscape.

群山是景色中**始終存在的特徵**。

MCQ-ready definition:

ever-present = always present or continuously noticeable

19. **ever-changing** — 不斷變化的

Practice 1

> We live in an **ever-changing world**.

我們生活在一個**不斷變化的世界**。

Practice 2

> Businesses must adapt to **ever-changing conditions**.

企業必須適應**持續轉變的環境**。

MCQ-ready definition:

ever-changing = changing continuously

20. **ever so + adjective/adverb — 非常；十分**

Especially BrE informal/old-fashioned in some contexts.

Practice 1

> She was **ever so pleased** with the album.

她對那本相簿**非常開心**。

Practice 2

> Thank you **ever so much**.

非常多謝你。

MCQ-ready definition:

ever so + adjective/adverb = very; extremely

中文：

非常；十分

21. **ever such + noun — 非常……的**

Especially BrE informal.

Practice 1

> She is **ever such a kind person**.

她真的是一個**非常善良的人**。

Practice 2

> We had **ever such a good time**.

我們玩得**非常開心**。

MCQ-ready definition:

ever such + noun phrase = very / extremely

This is less common than ordinary **very** and is mainly worth recognition.

22. **as ever** — 一如以往；和往常一樣

Practice 1

> She was, **as ever**, calm and patient.

她**一如以往**冷靜而有耐性。

Practice 2

> The café was busy **as ever**.

咖啡店**和往常一樣**繁忙。

MCQ-ready definition:

as ever = as usual; in the same way as always

23. **ever the + noun** — 一向都是.....的人；始終很.....

A stylistic/literary construction.

Practice 1

> **Ever the optimist**, he expected things to improve.

他**一向樂觀**，相信事情會改善。

Practice 2

> **Ever the professional**, she remained calm.

她**一向專業**，仍然保持冷靜。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****ever the X = characteristically and consistently being X****

中文：

****一向都是 X；始終保持 X 的特質****

24. ****for ever / forever — 永遠；一直****

Closely related historically and functionally.

Practice 1

> I will remember this ****forever****.

我會****永遠****記得這件事。

Practice 2

> We can't wait ****for ever****.

我們不能****一直等下去****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****forever / for ever = for all future time, or for a very long time****

Usage note:

* ****forever**** is standard as one word in modern English.

* ****for ever**** is also possible, especially in BrE and when emphasizing duration.

25. ****forever (老是；沒完沒了地) — 老是；不停地****

A hyperbolic everyday use.

Practice 1

> He's ****forever losing his keys****.

他**老是**弄丟鎖匙。

Practice 2

> She's **forever changing her mind**.

她**老是不斷改變主意**。

MCQ-ready definition:

forever + -ing = informal: repeatedly doing something, often annoyingly

Important distinction 1: **ever vs never**

ever

at any time.

never

at no time.

> Have you ever been there?

你曾經去過嗎？

> I've never been there.

我從未去過。

Important distinction 2: **ever vs already**

ever

asks whether something has happened at any time.

already

says something happened earlier than now/expected.

> Have you ever visited Rome?

你曾經去過羅馬嗎？

> Have you already visited Rome?

你已經去過羅馬了嗎？

Very different question.

Important distinction 3: **ever vs once**

ever

at any time, not specifying frequency.

once

one time / formerly.

> Have you ever met her?

你曾經見過她嗎？

> I met her once.

我見過她一次。

Important distinction 4: **ever with present perfect**

This is one of the most important grammar patterns:

> have/has + ever + past participle

Examples:

* have ever seen

* has ever done

* have ever given

It means:

at any time up to now

Your passage uses exactly this structure.

Important distinction 5: **ever** in questions vs positive statements

In ordinary affirmative statements, **ever** usually needs a special structure.

Natural:

- > Have you ever been there?
- > It's the best film I've ever seen.

But not normally:

- > *I ever went there.* ❌

Use:

- > I once went there.
- > I have been there before.

Important distinction 6: **ever** vs **before**

ever

any time.

before

earlier than now or another point.

- > Have you ever tried it?

人生中曾試過嗎？

- > Have you tried it before?

以前試過嗎？

Very close in many questions, but **ever** emphasizes the entire time range more strongly.

Important distinction 7: **ever before** vs **before**

before

earlier.

ever before

at any earlier time whatsoever.

> better than before

比以前好

> better than ever before

比過去任何時候都更好

The second is stronger.

Important distinction 8: **so far vs ever**

so far

up to now in an ongoing situation.

ever

at any time in the whole relevant period.

> So far, the course is easy.

到目前為止，課程很容易。

> It's the easiest course I've ever taken.

這是我曾修讀過最容易的課程。

Important distinction 9: **ever since vs since**

since

from a past point until now.

ever since

same core meaning, but often stronger/more emphatic.

> I've lived here since 2020.

我自 2020 年起住在這裏。

> I've loved the place ever since.

從那時起我一直很喜歡這裏。

Important distinction 10: **hardly ever vs never**

never

0 times.

hardly ever

almost never, but perhaps occasionally.

> I never eat sweets.

我從不吃甜食。

> I hardly ever eat sweets.

我幾乎不吃甜食。

Important distinction 11: **ever again in questions vs negatives**

Question

> Will I ever see her again?

我還會再見到她嗎？

Negative

> I don't want to see that again, ever.

我以後再也不想看到了。

The same idea concerns **any future time**.

Important distinction 12: **ever more vs more and more**

Both mean increasing degree.

ever more

more formal/literary.

more and more

more everyday.

> ever more difficult

愈來愈困難

> more and more difficult

愈來愈困難

Important distinction 13: **ever so vs so**

ever so

= very

> ever so kind

非常好

so

can mean:

* very

* therefore

* in this way

* etc.

So **ever so** is a fixed intensifying expression.

Important distinction 14: **forever vs ever**

ever

any time.

forever

for all future time / continuously for a very long time.

> Have you ever loved someone?

你曾經愛過某人嗎？

> I will love you forever.

我會永遠愛你。

Important distinction 15: **the best ever vs the best I've ever seen**

the best ever

compressed, often headline/informal style.

the best I've ever seen

full comparative experience structure.

Both can mean:

我有生以來見過最好的

Family-extension note

Ever has several high-value grammatical branches rather than a conventional lexical family:

1. **at any time**

- * Have you ever...?
- * the best I've ever seen

2. **strong comparison**

- * than ever
- * ever before
- * best ever

3. **continuity from the past**

- * ever since

4. **future recurrence**

- * ever again

5. **near-negation**

- * hardly ever
- * if ever

6. **continuous increase**

- * ever more
- * ever increasing
- * ever changing

7. **intensification**

- * ever so
- * ever such

8. **consistency**

- * as ever
- * ever the optimist

9. **related duration form**

- * forever / for ever

For learners, the biggest mistake is memorizing **ever = 曾經** and trying to use that Chinese meaning everywhere. Depending on structure:

ever = 曾經

ever = 任何時候

ever since = 自從.....一直

hardly ever = 幾乎從不

than ever = 比以往任何時候更

ever more = 愈來愈

ever so = 非常

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
-----	-----	-----
ever	曾經；任何時候	at any time
Have you ever...?	你曾經.....嗎？	life experience
have ever done	曾經做過	up to now
best/worst ever	歷來最好 / 最差	all-time comparison
ever before	以往任何時候	any earlier time
than ever	比以往更.....	stronger than before
more than ever	比以往任何時候更加	strongest current degree
ever since	自從.....一直	continuity
ever after	從此以後	from then onward
hardly ever	幾乎從不	almost never
rarely ever	極少	very seldom
if ever	即使有也很少	perhaps never
ever again	以後再一次	any future time
never ever	絕對不；永遠不	emphatic never
ever more	愈來愈	increasing degree
ever-increasing	不斷增加的	continuous growth
ever-present	一直存在的	always present
ever-changing	不斷變化的	continuous change
ever so	非常	intensifier
ever such	非常.....的	intensifier
as ever	一如以往	as usual
ever the optimist	一向樂觀的人	consistent trait
forever / for ever	永遠；一直	all future time
forever + -ing	老是.....	repeated behaviour

For your original sentence

> ...I still think it was one of the best presents I have **ever** given.

Here:

ever = 在我人生直到現在的任何時候；曾經

The structure is:

> **one of the best + plural noun + I have ever + past participle**

So:

> one of the best presents I have **ever given**

> = **我到目前為止曾經送過的最好禮物之一**

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 直到今天，我仍然覺得那是我**送過最好的禮物之一**。

Chinese often does not need to translate **ever** separately here because **「送過」** already naturally carries the life-experience meaning.